

The influence of social undermining on the service employee's customer-oriented boundary-spanning behavior

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Abstract

Purpose – This study aims to investigate the effect of social undermining on the service employees' boundary-spanning behavior though perceived fit with job (P-J fit). This study also aims to examine the moderating role of ethical climate in the relationship between service employees' perceived fit with job (P-J fit) and boundary-spanning behavior.

Design/methodology/approach – Using a sample of 469 Korean bank and insurance employees, research model and hypotheses were tested. Data analysis was performed using structural equation modeling and the hierarchical regression model.

Findings – The results showed that supervisor and co-worker undermining have detrimental influences on the service employee's perceived fit with job. P-J fit has a positive effect on employees' boundary-spanning behavior and this relationship was positively moderated by the employee's prevailing perception of organizational practices and procedures that have ethical content.

Research limitations/implications – This research should be evaluated in light of limitations, one of which is the reliance on cross-sectional data. The generalizability of this research model across settings and across outcome variables is still an open question. The measures of social undermining were based on participant perceptions, and in each case, participants make judgments about their negative behaviors retrospectively. Furthermore, the data were collected in Korea, so generalizing the hypothesized model beyond this setting is limited. Since Korea represents a distinct cultural and economic context, future research could examine the model in different countries.

Practical implications – The findings of this study confirm the crucial role of managers in creating an ethical climate where decisions are based on formally stated ethical guidelines. Such guidelines help service employees solve the ethical dilemmas that are common to their positions. These research findings demonstrate that creating an ethical climate is not only the right thing to do but also has significant benefits for both the service employees and the organization.

Originality/value – Considering the boundary-spanning role of the service employee, not only the organizational side (supervisor and co-worker undermining), but also the customer is specified as a major source of social undermining.

Keywords Boundary-spanning behavior, Ethical climate, Person-job fit, Social undermining

Paper type Research paper

An executive summary for managers and executive readers can be found at the end of this article.

Introduction

Interpersonal relationships and interactions among organization members are at least as important in the respects as other factors that have received far more attention from scholars in organizational behavior and industrial-organizational psychology, such as job-related attitudes, rewards and appraisal systems, and other aspects of employee behavior (Baron, 1996).

One of the most often invoked theoretical explanations for these findings is that employees view their relationships with the organization, authorities, and customers as social exchanges (Thau *et al.*, 2007). Given the importance of interpersonal relations in the workplace, it is surprising how

relatively little attention organizational researchers have devoted to this issue, especially to the concept of negative interactions in the workplace. Disregarding either the positive or negative aspects of social exchanges skews perception of the role that work relationships play in important organizational outcomes, and it ultimately obstructs our ability to develop an accurate understanding of social relationships and interactions (Duffy *et al.*, 2002).

This article takes an approach that recognizes the potential influence of the negative aspects of social relationships, or what Vinokur *et al.* (1996) refer to as social undermining, on employees' attitudinal and behavioral outcomes. Social undermining is defined in a work context as behavior intended to hinder, over time, a worker's ability to establish and maintain positive interpersonal relationships, work-related success, and a favorable reputation (Duffy *et al.*, 2002). Not only do employees who experience undermining react negatively in terms of attitudinal, health, and behavioral outcomes, they also react more strongly than they do to positive behaviors (e.g. Duffy *et al.*, 2002; Taylor, 1991).

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This study focuses on social undermining from the service employee's perspective. Considering the boundary-spanning role of the service employee, working environments of service employees tend to be unique. Thus, customer-employee interactions have characteristics distinct from organizational-insider interactions (Grandey *et al.*, 2007). Service employees play a crucial role in service delivery and building relationships with customers, as well as with coworkers and supervisors. Thus, service employees are required to respond to multiple demands from the organization, coworkers, and customers, making role stress an inevitable part of the job (Singh *et al.*, 1994). Stress research has often relied on the stimulus-response paradigm to suggest that service employees face stressful working conditions-as stressors, which can result in negative attitudinal and behavioral responses and strain (Netemeyer *et al.*, 2005).

This study addresses the three distinct sources of social undermining-supervisors, coworkers, and customers-since these are likely to be the most important functional and social constituencies of service employees. I derive predictions about social undermining and relevant work-related individual outcomes (P-J fit) based on the social exchange theory (SET). Person-Job (P-J) fit refers to individuals' congruence with the requirements of their job and the inducements provided to perform it (Bretz *et al.*, 1993; Edwards, 1991). Next, by integrating service employees' customer-oriented, boundary-spanning behaviors (service delivery, external representation, and internal influence), this study examines behavioral responses of social undermining. Finally, ethical climate is examined as a potential moderator of the association between P-J fit and customer-oriented, boundary-spanning behaviors (service delivery, external representation, and internal influence).

Conceptual development and hypothesis

Social undermining

The study of social undermining is based on Rook's (1984) social-psychological work on the quantity of problematic social exchanges in an individual's experience. According to Rook, problematic exchanges are actions by members of social networks that cause their targets to experience distress and to develop initial reservations about their relationships with other actors.

Duffy *et al.* (2002) defined social undermining in workplace contexts as "behaviors that hinder another's ability to establish and maintain positive interpersonal relationships, work-related success, and favorable reputation" (p. 333). Examples of undermining in workplace contexts include intentionally making someone feel incompetent, withholding important or required information, giving the silent treatment, talking behind someone's back, and spreading rumors about a particular individual. Social undermining differs from other constructs (e.g. abusive supervision or incivility) in the field in that it is concerned with the manner in which perpetrators can harm the relationships and success of their victims. While other mistreatment constructs do not specify the type of harm that victims will experience, this construct is explicit about its outcomes (Hershcovis, 2011).

Hershcovis (2011) argued that there are three key assumptions in the definition of social undermining. First, in contrast to incivility, where intent is ambiguous, this construct assumes intent on the part of the perpetrator. Second and most

notably, this construct implies an interference with relationships at work. In particular, this construct assumes that in the act of undermining a victim, the attitudes and behaviors of third parties toward the victim are influenced. Third, social undermining assumes particular outcomes within the definition. That is, social undermining should interfere with social relationships, diminish the work-related success of victims, and hinder victims' reputations (Hershcovis, 2011).

As a result, not only do employees who experience undermining react negatively in terms of attitudinal, health, and behavioral outcomes, but they react more strongly to undermining than they do to positive behaviors (e.g. Duffy *et al.*, 2002; Taylor, 1991).

While informative, the cumulative results from this literature leave several fundamental questions unanswered about how service employees respond to social undermining. In particular, investigations of previous research fail to capture the richer and more complex boundary-spanning environment in which service employees experience social undermining.

Hypothesis development

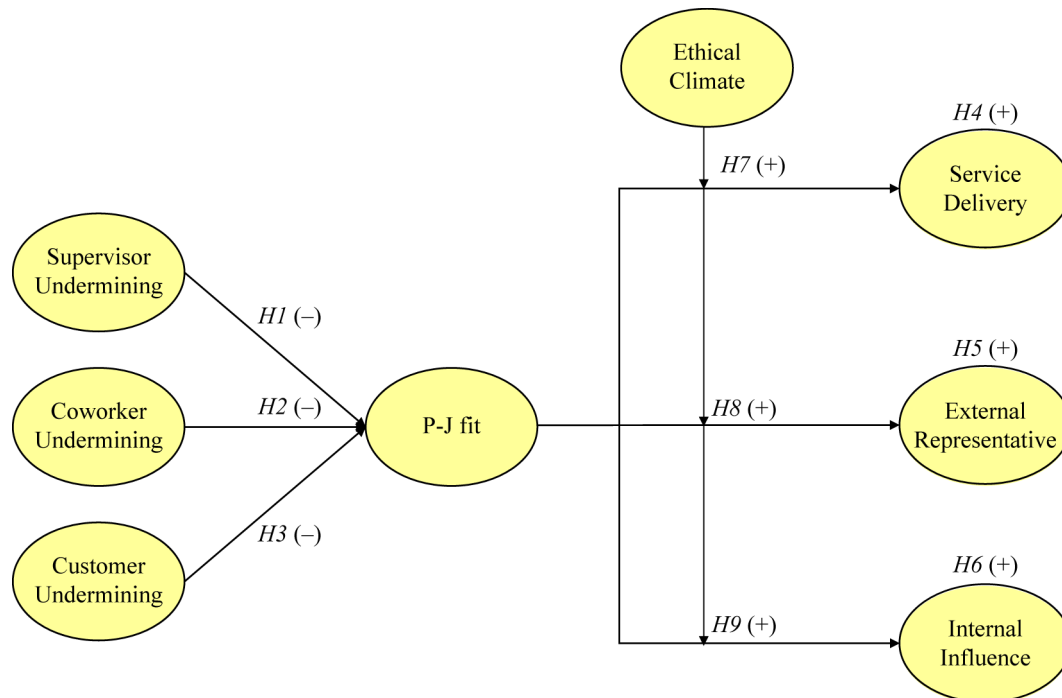
Figure 1 depicts the process whereby social undermining can lessen service employees' P-J fit, which is a potential driver of service employees' customer-oriented boundary-spanning behavior. Specific types of social undermining, including supervisor-, coworker-, and customer-undermining, can lead to a reduction in service employees' P-J fit and decrease service delivery, external representation, and internal influence. Furthermore, we suggest that the influence of perceived fit with jobs on boundary-spanning behavior can be moderated by ethical climate.

Person-Environment (P-E) fit has been the subject of much theoretical and empirical attention over the course of the last several decades. For example, researchers have contended that employees' well-being and success hinge on their fit with multiple components of the work environment, particularly with the job and organization (Bowen *et al.*, 1991; Kristof-Brown, 2000). Fit with task demands and psychological characteristics of a job likely serve as salient cues used in the development of job-related attitudes, as input for work-related decisions (Resick *et al.*, 2007).

Two distinct types of P-J fit have been identified in previous research. The first type, abilities-demand fit, is the congruence between individuals' skills and abilities and the specific demands of the job. When workers have the skills necessary to fulfill job demands, they are more likely to perform at a higher level, to meet the expectations of supervisors, and to remain on the job. The second type of P-J fit, needs-supplies fit, is achieved when individuals' needs are provided for by the supplies (rewards) of the job. When workers' needs for affiliation, autonomy, and financial security are supplied for by the organization in the form of compatible colleagues, scheduling autonomy, and generous compensation, workers experience greater job satisfaction and are more highly committed to the organization. These two different components of P-J fit (abilities-demand fit and needs-supplies fit) were initially studied as two separate types of fit but are now generally combined into the overall conceptualization of P-J fit (e.g. Cable and Derue, 2002; Scroggins, 2007).

According to abilities-demand fit, social undermining is highly demanding work-related stress. Even service employees who have the appropriate level of job abilities are susceptible to

Figure 1 Research model



increased social undermining and less perceived fit with their job. On the other hand, from the need-supply perspective, service employees who experience social undermining at their work need more resources to buffer the effect of job demands on their well-being. However, if service employees receive no support from their supervisors, coworkers, or customers, then they perceive less fit with their job.

Taylor (1991) argued that negative interpersonal events elicit affective, cognitive, and behavioral responses from individuals. Thus, it is logical to construe being the target of social undermining behaviors as a negative event that would relate to affective, cognitive, and behavioral outcomes. According to Bandura (1997), cognitively, negative events elicit increased attributional activity. Attribution for the cause of social undermining can easily be made to the specific perpetrator, but there are also multiple reasons to blame (an attribution process) the organization and job, because either can be seen as responsible for the actions and even the very presence of the perpetrator (Bowling and Beehr, 2006). Bowling and Beehr (2006) argued that targets of social undermining are likely to see the organization's climate and human resources systems as partially responsible through their effects on the nature of the workplace (presence of other stressors and presence of people who harass). Thus, service employees who experience social undermining from a workplace may attribute the cause of social undermining to their own job condition:

- H1. A service employee's perceived supervisor undermining has negative effects on perceived fit with job.
- H2. A service employee's perceived coworker undermining has negative effects on perceived fit with job.
- H3. A service employee's perceived customer undermining has negative effects on perceived fit with job.

Boundary-spanning personnel are those employees who cross internal and/or external organizational boundaries in the performance of their roles. As such, the boundary spanner is subject to the expectations and influence attempts of external agents, as well as from internal organizational members (Adams, 1976). Thus, customer-oriented boundary-spanning behavior can be defined as customer-contact employee behaviors that derive from their unique positions as boundary spanners of the firm (Bettencourt *et al.*, 2001; Chebat and Kollias, 2000).

The marketing and management literatures both identify three fundamental role-related impacts of customer-contact employees (Van Dyne *et al.*, 1994; Bettencourt *et al.*, 2001). First, service employees play an important part in representing the organization to outsiders and enhancing the firm's image and legitimacy through their advocacy of the firm and its products and services (Adams, 1976; Booms and Bitner, 1981; Bowen and Schneider, 1985). Second, the boundary-spanning position of service employees provides many opportunities to share information internally about evolving customer needs and possible improvements in product and service delivery (Schneider and Bowen, 1985; Zeithaml *et al.*, 1988). Third, service quality perceptions and customer satisfaction are largely dependent on service employee behaviors, such as courtesy, personal attentiveness, responsiveness, and keeping promises (Parasuraman *et al.*, 1988).

Based on these impacts, Bettencourt and Brown (2003), Bettencourt *et al.* (2001), and Marrone *et al.* (2007) provide three types of customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors that service employees may perform associated with linking the organization to its positional or actual customers:

- 1 external representation, being vocal advocates to outsiders of the organization's image, goods and services (Bowen and Schneider, 1985);
- 2 internal influence, taking individual initiative in communications to the firm and coworkers to improve service delivery by the organization, co-workers and oneself (Schneider and Bowen, 1993; Zeithaml *et al.*, 1988); and
- 3 service delivery, serving customers in a conscientious, responsive, flexible, and courteous manner (Parasuraman *et al.*, 1988).

Extensive empirical research supports the links between both types of P-J fit and important work attitudes and behaviors (Edwards, 1991; Edwards and Shipp, 2007; Kristof-Brown *et al.*, 2005). Fits with a task and psychological characteristics of a job likely serve as salient cues used in the development of job-related attitudes, and as input for work-related decisions. Although customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors are not formally or explicitly recognized as part of a job description, in the aggregate, they promote the functioning of the organization. Thus, it is suggested that employees who engage in extra-role activities because they have positive feelings about their colleagues, supervisors, their job, or their work overall, or because they expect the appreciation of these actions by their supervisors or colleagues will result in secondary benefits, capturing the expectancy-beliefs and goals-values cognitive units. Thus, service employees who feel satisfied with their jobs will be keener to participate in extra-role activities, and if treated fairly, will also be keener to engage in contextual performance (Nikolaou, 2003):

- H4. A service employee's perceived fit with their job has a positive effect on the employee's service delivery.
- H5. A service employee's perceived fit with their job has a positive effect on the employee's external representation.
- H6. A service employee's perceived fit with their job has a positive effect on the employee's internal influence.

Ethical perceptions about a firm are closely related to its public image and success in building long-term relationships with customers (Schwepker and Hartline, 2005). Service employees, as boundary spanners, are representatives of the firm and are responsible for managing relationships with customers. In light of this, there has been a growing need to investigate the role of ethics on service employee's success (Valentine and Barnett, 2003).

Evidence indicates that the creation of a strong corporate ethical climate is essential to prevent unethical acts (Ahmed and Machold, 2004; Douglas *et al.*, 2001). Although a variety of research have explored the positive effect of ethical climate on individual and organizational outcomes, its effects on service employee's customer-oriented boundary-spanning behavior have rarely been examined.

Kristof-Brown *et al.* (2005) argue that there is need for future research on personal and situational characteristics that moderate P-J fit and outcome relationships. Compared to personal characteristics, few studies have examined the impact of situational moderators on P-J fit effects. In this study, I incorporate the interaction effect between ethical climate and P-J fit on service employees' customer-oriented

boundary-spanning behavior, as this area seems particularly in need of research.

The ethical climate within an organization is an important factor affecting employees' perceptions about the nature of the relational contract between themselves and their employer (Barnett and Schubert, 2002). Such a relationship is a "psychological contract" between the employer and employee (Lester *et al.*, 2002) and a "mutual covenant" to the welfare of both parties; it is a shared set of values (Van Dyne *et al.*, 1994). Members who feel bound to the organization and perceive that they personally benefit from the organization are more likely to reciprocate their goodwill in the form of organizational citizenship behavior (Organ, 1988).

Social exchange theory (Blau, 1964) can be used to explain why service employees exhibit boundary-spanning behavior. The theory suggests that voluntary and prosocial behavior can be expected when an employee experiences positive effects from an organization and is motivated to reciprocate these positive feelings towards the organization.

It is believed that the relationship between P-J fit and customer-oriented boundary-spanning behavior (service delivery, external representation and internal influence) will be stronger when a service employee perceives a strong ethical climate in his or her service organization:

- H7. A positive effect of perceived fit with job on service delivery increases, when the service employee's perceived ethical climate increases.
- H8. A positive effect of perceived fit with job on external representation increases, when the service employee's perceived ethical climate increases.
- H9. A positive effect of perceived fit with job on internal influence increases, when the service employee's perceived ethical climate increases.

Methodology

Measures

All measures are adapted from or developed based on prior research. Individual measurement items for the constructs are listed in Appendix.

I assessed individual perceptions of supervisor and coworker undermining with the 13 item scale from Duffy *et al.* (2002). Each individual reported how often their supervisor intentionally engaged in undermining behaviors. Participants also responded to the thirteen items concerning how often coworkers intentionally engaged in undermining behaviors directed at them. Response options ranged from 1 (not at all) to 7 (every day). Customer undermining measurement scales were revised to reflect how often customers intentionally engaged in undermining behaviors based on Duffy *et al.*'s (2002) supervisor and coworker undermining scales. Among the thirteen item scales, six items were deleted based on the preliminary interviews with service employees; they considered these items to be related to supervisor or coworker undermining rather than undermining from customers.

Person-job fit was assessed by four items developed by Saks and Ashforth (1997). A sample item is: "To what extent do your knowledge, skills, and abilities 'match' or fit the requirements of the job?" The response format for P-J fit was a seven-point Likert scale with 1 representing "not at all" and 7 representing "completely."

To measure the ethical climate, three items of Cadogan and Lee's (2009) research were used. Cadogan and Lee (2009) modified and extended Hunt *et al.*'s (1989) measure of ethical values. Specifically, Hunt *et al.* (1989) state that attempting to assess the ethical standards/values of organizations will measure the degree to which organizations take an interest in ethical issues and act in an ethical manner.

Bettencourt *et al.* (2005) developed the customer-oriented boundary-spanning behavior measures based on their conceptual definitions and prior research involving measurement of related pro-social behaviors and/or service quality constructs. External representation was measured using a four-item scale designed to measure the extent to which an employee is a vocal advocate to outsiders of his/her organization's image, goods, and services. Internal influence was measured with a four-item scale intended to capture the extent to which a person takes individual initiative in communicating to the firm and co-workers ways to improve service delivery by the organization, co-workers, and the individual employee. Service delivery was measured with a five-item scale that reflects the extent to which the employees serve customers in a conscientious, responsive, flexible, and courteous manner.

Sampling procedure and data collection

Data for the study were collected from a cross-sectional sample of retail bank and insurance employees in South Korea. The sample contained responses from service employees. Participation was solicited from various large banks across the country. All the organizations involved in the data collection offered services and sell service products directly to customers.

The instrument was prepared in English and then translated into Korean. It was checked for accuracy in line with conventional back-translation processes. Data were collected onsite from each participating bank and insurance company. The sample for the study was drawn with the help of chief executive officers (CEOs) who worked for the ten top ranked banks and the 15 top ranked insurance companies with headquarters in Seoul. In the initial contact, a cover letter was mailed explaining the purpose of the survey to the top manager and asking them to persuade their branch managers to participate in the survey. Four out of ten CEOs in the banking industry and 8 out of 15 CEOs of insurance companies agreed to ask their branch managers to participate in the survey. Based on the list of branches suggested by CEOs, branch managers were asked to help with the survey administration.

An interviewer scheduled appointments with the branch manager as an informant, who then introduced the interviewer to the other employees in that branch. The interviewer presented the respondents with the survey questionnaire and collected the questionnaire upon completion.

Sample characteristics

Questionnaires were distributed to 500 service employees across several banks. Of these, 346 completed questionnaires were returned, for a response rate of 69.2 percent (interviewer presence certainly aided this response rate). The employee sample was 49 percent male, with an average age of 35 years

and ten-year tenure in their current position; 68.6 percent of the sample had a university degree.

Based on Armstrong and Overton's (1977) extrapolation technique, I compared the means for the three types of social undermining, P-J fit, ethical climate, and customer-oriented boundary-spanning behavior (service delivery, external representation, and internal influence) for the first third and the last third of respondents. I found no significant differences. Armstrong and Overton (1977) found that later responders closely resembled non-responders. Thus, if there is little difference between early and late responders, nonresponse bias may not be an issue.

Research findings

Measurement model analysis and results

To analyze the data, a structural equation model procedure using LISREL 8.5 was employed (Jöreskog and Sörbom, 1996). Reliabilities of the individual measurement scales were assessed using Cronbach's alpha and Fornell and Larcker's (1981) composite reliability formula. The average variance extracted, composite reliability calculations, and items appear in Appendix. The measurement model in this study consists of 55 reflective indicators and eight correlated latent factors that correspond to the eight constructs of the study, which is depicted in Figure 1.

The first step in the analysis was to test the hypothesized measurement relationships and evaluate the reliability and discriminant validity of the constructs. To do this, an eight-construct confirmatory factor analysis was estimated using the covariance matrix as the input. Overall, the confirmatory factor model fit the data very well. The chi-square (df) was 889.56 (349), the comparative fit index (CFI) was 0.99, the root mean squared error approximation (RMSEA) was 0.058, the normed fit index (NFI) was 0.98, and the relative fit index (RFI) was 0.98 (Table I).

As indicated in the Appendix, the Cronbach alpha reliability estimates were all well above Nunnally's (1978) recommended level of 0.70. Fornell and Larcker's (1981) index of the average amount of variance that each latent factor accounted for in its indicators ($\rho_{vc}(\eta)$) was well above the recommended level of 0.50 for all of the constructs. Evidence of discriminant validity is provided by the fact that all of the construct intercorrelations were significantly ($p < 0.05$) less than 1.00, and the variance shared by any two constructs (i.e. the square of their intercorrelation) was always less than the $\rho_{vc}(\eta)$'s for the constructs.

To access the potential common-method bias, I applied the "MV" market method and used a scale theoretically unrelated to at least one scale in the analysis as the MV market, which offered a proxy for common method variance (Lindell and Whitney, 2001).

I used a five-item scale that measured the subject's perceived family meal importance (Putrevu and Ratchford, 1997; Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.77$) and selected the lowest positive correlation ($\gamma = 0.032$) between MV market and other variables to adjust the construct correlation and statistical significance (Lindell and Whitney, 2001). None of the significant correlations became insignificant after adjustment (see Table II). Therefore, common-method bias was unlikely to be a serious concern.

Table I Measure correlations

	SPU	COU	CUU	PJF	EC	SD	ER	II
SPU		0.437 **	0.336 **	−0.252 **	0.217 **	−0.274 **	−0.278 **	−0.181 **
COU	0.446 **		0.463 **	−0.293 **	−0.376 **	−0.297 **	−0.389 **	−0.319 **
CUU	0.348 **	0.474 **		−0.440 **	−0.488 **	−0.426 **	−0.384 **	−0.200 **
PJF	−0.203 **	−0.246 **	−0.394 **		0.388 **	0.282 **	0.373 **	0.224 **
EC	0.233 **	−0.326 **	−0.441 **	0.398 **		0.300 **	0.227 **	0.249 **
SD	−0.227 **	−0.250 **	−0.381 **	0.296 **	0.313 **		0.230 **	0.290 **
ER	−0.231 **	−0.345 **	−0.340 **	0.384 **	0.243 **	0.246 **		0.330 **
II	−0.137 **	−0.277 **	−0.162 **	0.240 **	0.267 **	0.304 **	0.346 **	
MV	−0.059 **	−0.052 **	−0.040 **	0.080 **	0.073 **	0.032 **	0.097 **	

Notes: Supervisor undermining (SPU); Coworker undermining (COU); Customer undermining (CUU); Person-job fit (PJF); Ethical climate (EC); Service delivery (SD); External representation (ER); Internal influence (II); MV Marker (MV); * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$

Table II Result of hypothesized relationships

Hypothesized relationships	Unstandardized estimates	t-value	Std error	Conclusion
Supervisor undermining → Person-organization fit	−0.40	−4.95	0.08	H1 supported
Coworker undermining → Person-organization fit	−0.16	−2.00	0.08	H2 supported
Customer undermining → Person-organization fit	−0.04	−0.59	0.07	H3 rejected
Person-organization fit → Service delivery	0.75	14.85	0.05	H4 supported
Person-organization fit → External representation	0.64	12.18	0.05	H5 supported
Person-organization fit → Internal influence	0.75	14.10	0.05	H6 supported

Results and analysis

I tested the hypotheses proposed herein using structural equation modeling with LISREL 8.5 (Jöreskog and Sörbom, 1996). The overall fit of this model was good. The chi-square (df) was 749.59 (266), the comparative fit index (CFI) was 0.99, the root mean squared error approximation (RMSEA) was 0.062, the normed fit index (NFI) was 0.98, the goodness fit index (GFI) was 0.89, and relative fit index (RFI) was 0.98.

The structural estimates of this model are shown in Table II. As shown, the analyses provide support for all hypothesized relationships but H3.

H1-H3, respectively, hypothesize that social undermining from different sources is negatively associated with service employee P-J fit. H1 argues that supervisor undermining influences employees' perceived fit with job. The results lend strong support for this relationship in that supervisor undermining and P-J fit ($\gamma = -0.40$, $p < 0.01$) is negatively and statistically significant. H2 states that lower perceived undermining by coworkers, increases the employee's perceived fit with job. Structural equation modeling supports this view through finding a negative ($\gamma = -2.00$, $p < 0.05$) and significant association between the degree of perceived coworker undermining and P-J fit. H3 contends that a service employee's perceived customer undermining is negatively associated with service employee's P-J fit. The findings of the study could not support this view, as it uncovered a nonsignificant association ($\gamma = -0.04$, $p > 0.05$) thus, H3 is rejected.

H4-H6 argue that service employees' P-J fit is positively related to employees' service delivery (H4), external representation (H5), and internal influence (H6) respectively. H4 is strongly supported by the results in a highly significant parameter ($\gamma = 0.75$, $p < 0.01$) and is

therefore accepted. H5 contends that a service employee's P-J fit is positively associated with service employee's external representation. The findings of the study support this view—there is a significant positive association ($\gamma = 0.75$, $p < 0.01$), which leads to the conclusion that H5 is accepted. Finally, H6 contends that P-J fit enhances service employee's internal influence. The results lend strong support to this relationship between P-J fit and internal influence ($\gamma = 0.64$, $p < 0.01$).

Moderating effects of ethical climate

H7, H8, and H9 were tested via hierarchical moderated regression analysis. As suggested by Aiken and West (1991), the variables of perceived fit with job and ethical climate were mean-centered to minimize the threat of multi-collinearity in equations where I created interaction terms. The values of the variance inflation factor were well below the cut-off of 10 recommended by Neter *et al.* (1985).

Table III shows the results of my hypotheses. H7 posits that P-J fit will be more positively related to service delivery when service employees perceive a positive ethical climate in their organization. The results of the moderated analysis demonstrate a positive and significant interaction between P-J fit and ethical climate ($\beta = 0.815$, $p < 0.01$). These findings support H7, which states service employees demonstrate more service delivery behavior when they perceive a positive ethical climate.

H8 posits that perceived fit with job will be more positively related to service employees' external representation when they perceive a positive ethical climate. However, the results indicate that the interaction between P-J fit and ethical climate has no significant effect ($\beta = -0.087$, $p > 0.1$) on external representation. Thus H8 was rejected.

Table III Results of moderating effects of ethical climate

Variable	Step 1		Step 2		Step 3	
	b	t-value	b	t-value	b	t-value
DV = Service delivery (H7)						
Main effects:						
PJF	0.595 *	15.922	0.325 *	6.632	0.182 *	1.072
EC			0.387 *	7.890	0.019 *	0.145
Interactions:						
PJF X EC					0.815 *	3.119
R ²		0.354		0.431		0.442
ΔR ²				0.077		0.012
F2		253.519 *		174.657 *		121.881 *
ΔF2				78.862 *		52.776 *
DV = External Representation (H8)						
Main effects:						
PJF	0.682	20.095 *	0.591	12.570 *	0.645	3.924 *
EC			0.130	2.768 *	0.169	1.366
Interactions:						
PJF X EC					−0.087	−0.342
R ²		0.465		0.474		0.474
ΔR ²				0.009		0.000
F2		403.826 *		208.641 *		138.868 *
ΔF2				195.185 *		69.773 *
DV = Internal Influence (H9)						
Main effects:						
PJF	0.537	13.696 *	0.410	7.588 *	0.071	0.378
EC			0.181	3.342 *	0.170	1.210
Interactions:						
PJF X EC					0.775	2.678 *
R ²		0.288		0.305		0.315
ΔR ²				0.017		0.011
F2		187.586 *		101.432 *		70.914 *
ΔF2				86.154 *		30.518 *

Note: Perceived fit with job (PJF), Ethical climate (EC); b is standardized coefficient beta; *Significant at 0.01 level

Finally, H9 posits that P-J fit will be more positively related to service employees' internal influence when they perceive a positive ethical climate. The results of the moderated analysis demonstrate a positive and significant interaction between perceived fit with job and the ethical climate ($\beta = 0.775$, $p < 0.01$). These findings support H9, stating that high P-J fit is associated with more internal influence when service employee perceived their organization's climate as ethical.

Discussion

The findings of this study contribute to our understanding of negative social interactions relating to service employees' P-J fit and behavioral responses. In line with social exchange theory, this study extended the focus on employee person-environment fit to include not only organizational environment, but customer-related aspects of service employees' work as well.

The results show that when service employees perceive social undermining from supervisor and coworkers, they also perceive less fit with job, which in turn is negatively related to a service employee's behaviors toward their organization and

customers. However, the results showed that undermining by customers has no significant effect on an employee's perceived fit with an organization. One possible reason for this can be explained by contract research on the power asymmetry that exists between supervisors, coworkers, and customers. Relational contract research suggests that service employees are more likely to perceive a violation of the psychological contract if there is power asymmetry. Compared to the supervisors and coworkers, customers may have weak power over the service employee. Thus, service employees may not be susceptible to customer undermining, because they perceive fewer discrepancies of power from their customers. Thus, future theoretical and empirical work on social undermining may benefit from consideration of the extent psychological and relational research.

The findings of this study suggested that service employees' P-J fit increases their customer-oriented boundary-spanning behavior. For the majority of service employees, service delivery behaviors are likely to be relatively more role-prescribed due to their frequent specification in job descriptions, training materials, and performance evaluation forms (Bettencourt and Brown, 2003). However, external

representation and internal influence behaviors are likely to be relatively more discretionary and related to “extra” role behaviors (Bettencourt and Brown, 2003). Thus, perceived fit with job has a beneficial effect on increasing “in-role,” as well as “extra-role,” behaviors of service employees.

Furthermore, when service employees perceived a more ethical climate in their organization, the influence of P-J fit on service delivery and internal influence were increased. However, I could not find a moderating effect of ethical climate in the relationship between P-J fit and external representation. One of the possible reasons for this non-significant result is that external representations can be regarded as an overstatement of their own companies' reputation, if service employees are highly ethically oriented. Thus further research is needed to examine the negative effects of ethical climate on service employee's external representation.

Managerial implications

This research also has implications for management practice with respect to the understanding of social undermining, person-job fit, ethical climate, and boundary-spanning behavior. First, three sources of social undermining were compared to determine their relative influence from an employee's perspective. The results showed that a supervisor is the most influential source of social undermining on service workers' P-J fit. Contract research may also helpful in explaining the different effects for supervisor and coworker undermining. That is, although both supervisor and coworker undermining were significantly linked with a range of employee outcomes, supervisor undermining was a significantly stronger predictor of P-J fit. The power asymmetry that exists within the supervisor-subordinate relationship may be an important factor in a supervisor undermining and P-J fit relationship. Relational contract research suggests that employees are more likely to perceive a violation of the psychological contract if there is power asymmetry (Morrison and Robinson, 1997). Thus, managers must understand the effects of negative interaction with subordinates on employees' attitudinal and behavioral responses. According to Rook (1984), negative social interactions have more potent effects on well-being than positive interaction (p. 1106). Thus, managers should focus on reducing the negative effects of social undermining rather than increasing the positive effects of social support.

The social exchange relationship appears especially important for motivating the more extra-role forms of customer-oriented boundary-spanning behavior; this research demonstrates that perceived fit with job plays a key mediating role between social undermining and boundary-spanning behavior. As such, in situations where employees perceive less fit with their own job, service employees show low service delivery, external representation, and internal influence. Thus, even though managers cannot control social undermining from various sources, they should focus on enhancing service employees' perceived fit with job though reducing job ambiguity and increasing job autonomy and social support.

The findings of this study confirm the crucial role of managers in creating an ethical climate where decisions are based on formally stated ethical guidelines. Such guidelines help service employees solve the ethical dilemmas that are

common to their positions. These research findings demonstrate that creating an ethical climate is not only the right thing to do but also has significant benefits for both the service employees and the organization. For example, a boundary-spanning employees who perceives his or her work environment as relatively ethical likely perceives less conflict and ambiguity, is more satisfied with their job, and is more committed to the organization (Babin *et al.*, 2000).

According to Schwepker *et al.* (1997), clearly defining and enforcing ethical codes and policies, proper selection of individuals, training programs, and socialization of desired ethical behaviors are the foremost mechanisms for promoting a positive ethical climate. Managers may enact or alter several of these types of mechanisms to influence service employees' perceptions of ethical climate.

Conclusion

This study extends the literature by demonstrating that it is important to explicitly consider boundary-spanning contexts when investigating the effects of negative interactions. By doing so, I synthesized and integrated service and organizational literatures on boundary-spanning behavior and social undermining, which allows us to consider the various sources of social undermining that service employees experience. In summary, this research has demonstrated the hindrances of social undermining on an organization on service employees' P-J fit and customer-oriented boundary-spanning behavior. Slightly mixed results were found regarding the moderating role of ethical climate in the links between P-J fit and boundary-spanning behavior.

Limitation and future research

This research should be evaluated in light of limitations, one of which is the reliance on cross-sectional data. Although the proposed model assumed a certain casual sequence, one cannot rule out other casual explanations. For example, boundary-spanning behavior might decrease undermining behaviors from supervisors, coworkers, and customers. Researchers who observe group contexts over different time periods might overcome this limitation.

The generalizability of this research model across settings and across outcome variables is still an open question. The measures of social undermining were based on participant perceptions, and in each case, participants make judgments about their negative behaviors retrospectively. According to the characteristics of deviant behavior, subjects might report less negative behaviors than they actually experienced. Furthermore, the data were collected in Korea, so generalizing the hypothesized model beyond this setting is limited. Since Korea represents a distinct cultural and economic context, future research could examine the model in different countries. While replicating the study in other countries might be useful for generalizability, it is important to keep in mind that the hypotheses in this study are based on research conducted previously in other countries.

Several research possibilities exist that would extend the findings of this study. This research did not consider the effect of social support or compare its relative effect with social undermining. However, based on negative asymmetry theory, one might expect the explanatory power of social undermining to be greater than that of social support.

This research focused on employee perceptions and used fit with job as a mediator. It did not consider the cognitive side of the employee. For future research, examining the role of cognitive structure such as employee role perceptions or justice perceptions in the relationship between social undermining and customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors, might offer new insight.

Recent research by Donovan *et al.* (2004) suggests that it would also be worthwhile to consider individual customer orientation as an antecedent to employee boundary-spanning behavior. Their research also suggests that it would be worthwhile to investigate the roles of job satisfaction and organizational commitment as mediators of any effect of customer orientation, as a predictor of boundary-spanning behavior. In short, many other variables may be involved in this process. The current study simply serves as a foundation from which to build.

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Appendix

Table A1 Measures of variables

Construct and source	Scales	Cronbach's α , CR and AVE
Social undermining (Duffy <i>et al.</i> , 2002)	Supervisor undermining	Reliability = 0.939 CR = 0.898 AVE = 0.709
	Hurt your feeling? Put you down when questioned work procedures? Undermined your effort to be successful on the job? Let you know they did not like you or something about you? Talked bad about you behind your back? Insulted you? Belittled you or your idea? Spread rumors about you? Made you feel incompetent? Delay work to make you look bad or slow you down? Talked down to you? Gave you the silent treatment? Did not defend you when people spoke poorly of you? Insulted you? Gave you the silent treatment? Spread rumors about you? Delay work to make you look bad or slow you down? Belittled you or your idea? Hurt your feeling? Talked bad about you behind your back? Criticized the way you handled things on the job in a way that was not helpful? Did not give as much help as they promised? Gave you incorrect or misleading information about the job? Let you know they did not like or something about you? Did not defend you when people spoke poorly of you? Hurt your feeling? Insulted you? Talked bad about you behind your back? Talked down to you? Spread rumors about you? Let you know they did not like you or something about you? Undermined your effort to be successful on the job?	Reliability = 0.932 CR = 0.930 AVE = 0.761
Coworker undermining		
Customer undermining		
		Reliability = 0.937 CR = 0.934 AVE = 0.779
P-J fit (Saks and Ashforth, 1997)		
		Reliability = 0.858 CR = 0.909 AVE = 0.770
Ethical climate (Cadogan and Lee, 2009)		
		Reliability = 0.808 CR = 0.920 AVE = 0.756
Boundary spanning behavior (Bettencourt <i>et al.</i> , 2005)		
		Reliability = 0.874 CR = 0.892 AVE = 0.647
Service delivery		
		Reliability = 0.916 CR = 0.919 AVE = 0.793
External representation		
		Reliability = 0.871 CR = 0.773 AVE = 0.642
Internal influence		

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Executive summary and implications for managers and executives

This summary has been provided to allow managers and executives a rapid appreciation of the content of this article. Those with a particular interest in the topic covered may then read the article in toto to take advantage of the more comprehensive description of the research undertaken and its results to get the full benefits of the material present.

Backbiting, malicious gossip, bullying, undermining – all are despicable actions which make life difficult or even unbearably miserable for victims, whether at school, work or elsewhere. The objectionable perpetrators have a knack of belittling and insulting people, spreading rumors, giving them the “silent treatment”, deliberately passing on misleading information or failing to defend them when called upon.

It is not rocket science to convince managers that allowing these unpleasant people to poison relationships within the organization is bad for employees’ morale and health – something which inevitably leads to it being bad for business. So what’s to be done about it? Given the importance of interpersonal relations in the workplace – especially the effect of corrosively negative interactions – it is an issue managers ignore at their peril.

When service employees perceive social undermining from a supervisor and coworkers, they also perceive less “fit” with job, which in turn is negatively related to their behaviors toward the organization and its customers. Person-Job (P-J) fit refers to individuals’ congruence with the requirements of their job and the inducements provided to perform it. However, Jaewon Yoo’s study “The influence of social undermining on the service employee’s customer-oriented boundary-spanning behavior” showed that undermining by customers had no significant effect on an employee’s perceived fit with an organization.

One possible reason for this can be explained by the power asymmetry that exists between supervisors, coworkers, and customers. Service employees are more likely to perceive a violation of the “psychological contract” if there is power asymmetry. Compared to the supervisors and coworkers, customers may have weak power over the service employee. Therefore, service employees may not be susceptible to customer undermining, because they perceive fewer discrepancies of power from their customers.

The study addresses three distinct sources of social undermining – supervisors, coworkers, and customers. By integrating service employees’ customer-oriented, boundary-spanning behaviors (service delivery, external representation, and internal influence), the study examines the behavioral responses of social undermining. Ethical climate is also examined as a potential moderator of the association between

P-J fit and customer-oriented, boundary-spanning behaviors (service delivery, external representation, and internal influence).

The study confirms the crucial role of managers in creating an ethical climate where decisions are based on formally stated ethical guidelines. Such guidelines help service employees solve the ethical dilemmas that are common to their positions. Creating an ethical climate is not only the right thing to do but also has significant benefits for both the service employees and the organization. Managers must understand the effects of negative interaction with subordinates on employees’ attitudinal and behavioral responses. They should focus on reducing the negative effects of social undermining rather than increasing the positive effects of social support.

Considering the boundary-spanning role of the service employee, their working environments tend to be unique because customer-employee interactions have characteristics distinct from organizational-insider interactions. Service employees play a crucial role in service delivery and building relationships with customers, as well as with coworkers and supervisors. As a result they have to respond to multiple demands from the organization, coworkers, and customers, making role stress an inevitable part of the job.

Social exchange relationship appears especially important for motivating the more extra-role forms of customer-oriented boundary-spanning behavior, and perceived fit with job plays a key mediating role between social undermining and boundary-spanning behavior. As such, in situations where employees perceive less fit with their own job, service employees show low service delivery, external representation, and internal influence. So, even though managers cannot control social undermining from various sources, they should focus on enhancing service employees’ perceived fit with the job through reducing job ambiguity and increasing job autonomy and social support. They should bear in mind previous research which maintains that clearly defining and enforcing ethical codes and policies, proper selection of individuals, training programs, and socialization of desired ethical behaviors are the foremost mechanisms for promoting a positive ethical climate.

It has been argued that there are three key assumptions in the definition of social undermining. First, in contrast to incivility, where intent is ambiguous, social undermining assumes intent on the part of the perpetrator. Second and most notably, it implies an interference with relationships at work. In particular, it assumes that in the act of undermining a victim, the attitudes and behaviors of third parties toward the victim are influenced. Third, social undermining assumes particular outcomes within the definition. That is, social undermining should interfere with social relationships, diminish the work-related success of victims, and hinder victims’ reputations.

As a result, not only do employees who experience undermining react negatively in terms of attitudinal, health, and behavioral outcomes, but they react more strongly to undermining than they do to positive behaviors – hence the advice to managers to focus more on reducing the negative effects of social undermining rather than increasing the positive effects of social support.

(A précis of the article “The influence of social undermining on the service employee’s customer-oriented boundary-spanning behavior”, Supplied by Marketing Consultants for Emerald.)